the "greatest mathematical stylist", perhaps to the point of championing a "triumph of style over substance" [**6**, pp. 1349, 1348, 1344, 1350].

Eilenberg's style called for a minimalist approach, which his colleague described as "always to find the absolutely essential ingredients in any problem and work only with those ingredients and nothing else — in other words, get rid of all the superfluous information". Once asked if he could eat Chinese food with three chopsticks, he immediately answered in the affirmative and explained, "I'll take the three chopsticks, I'll put one of them aside on the table, and I'll use the other two" [**7**, p. 361].

Eilenberg and Mac Lane pushed the homological envelope into more complicated spaces in their joint 1942 paper "Natural Isomorphisms in Group Theory", which introduced the notion of a functor. André Weil, who reviewed their article in *Mathematical Reviews*, did not merely summarize it but added a remarkable note of praise. He wrote that the authors succeeded in finding "a precise definition" for the "vague idea of covariance and contravariance", "which is likely to be helpful in classifying and systematizing known results and also in looking for new relations between groups" (Weil in [**4**, p. 743]).

In the war years both Mac Lane and Eilenberg came to New York to work for the Applied Mathematics Group at Columbia University under the National Defense Research Council. They toiled on problems of airborne fire control during the day and on pure mathematics at night. While dealing with the concrete problem of computing the cohomology of the solenoid, they arrived at their universal coefficient theorem and the very general and abstract notions of category and functor. "These notions were so general", Mac Lane recalled, "that they hardly seemed to be real mathematics — would our mathematical colleagues accept them?" Mac Lane and Eilenberg hid their anxiety behind the jocular label "general abstract nonsense", by which they occasionally referred to their subject. "We didn't really mean the nonsense part, and we were proud of its generality", admitted Mac Lane [**33**, pp. 125–126].

In 1945 Eilenberg and Mac Lane summed up their findings in the article "General Theory of Natural Equivalences", which for the